

ECON 1001: Principles of Microeconomics

Spring 2026

Syllabus

Teaching Staff and Key Logistical Details

Instructor: David Burk (dmb303@georgetown.edu)

Instructor office hours: TBA on Canvas.

Teaching Assistants: TBA on Canvas.

TA office hours: TBA on Canvas.

Lecture Time: Tuesdays and Thursdays, 2p – 3:15p

Lecture Location: ICC Auditorium

Exam Times: Feb. 12 (during class), Mar. 26 (during class), and May 8 (12:30p-2:30p)

TL;DR

You should read the entire syllabus. But here are some essentials:

- You **MUST** purchase *Achieve*, which provides electronic access to the textbook as well as many of the assignments. To do this, click on “Problem Set 0” on the Canvas page: it will take you to the purchasing portal.
- We will drop your lowest two problem set scores. (But we generally will not extend the deadlines.)

Course Description

Welcome to economics! In this course, you will develop a way of thinking that is useful for understanding all sorts of human endeavors. “Thinking like an economist” of course will help you understand the economy and business decisions, but it will also help you analyze the news, social policy, trends, and even many aspects of your personal life.

In particular, the course will cover opportunity cost, willingness to pay, demand, supply, elasticity, equilibrium, how markets function, social welfare, market imperfections and solutions to the consequences of those imperfections, government intervention in markets, optimal pricing, decisions under uncertainty, and other related topics.

This course is challenging, but students who engage steadily and practice the way economists think tend to do well.

Resources

Course Canvas Site: This is the course hub! Check it frequently. Announcements posted on Canvas should be considered authoritative and may supersede information in this syllabus.

Textbook: Betsey Stevenson and Justin Wolfers, *Principles of Microeconomics*, third edition. This is an excellent text that we will follow quite closely. **See below for important information on ordering the text.**

Online Course Supplement: Achieve is an online resource that includes electronic access to the textbook and is required for this course. We will administer most assignments through Achieve.

The reason we use Achieve is that it provides structured practice, immediate feedback, and multiple attempts on problems that help you learn to think like an economist. We use Achieve it because it meaningfully improves students' ability to reason through economic problems.

In addition to required assignments, Achieve includes optional practice problems, quizzes, and explanations that many students in past semesters have found helpful.

Recitations: Each week in your recitation section, a TA will cover some material that emphasizes topics from the previous two or three lectures. TAs will not cover new topics but will present additional examples or practice problems. The TA will also take questions. If you think a mini-lecture on a topic from the TA would be helpful, you might contact your TA ahead of time so they can prepare something in advance.

Purchasing the Textbook and Achieve

Achieve—an online resource that includes electronic access to the textbook described above—is required. Clicking on “Problem Set 0” on Canvas will take you to the purchasing portal.

Achieve comes with electronic access to the textbook, but if you want a physical copy of the text you can choose one at the purchasing portal. To purchase, you will need to use a US credit card or PayPal.

Evaluation and Learning Activities

I want to evaluate your ability to “think like an economist,” using the concepts and frameworks we develop in the course. To succeed, you will need to become comfortable making economic arguments—using models and reasoning to explain behavior and outcomes. A memorization-heavy approach will not be a very good strategy. All elements of the course are designed to help you develop this skill.

You will be evaluated based on assignments, a small project, and—most importantly—exams. The problem sets are intentionally low-pressure, and it is not difficult to earn a good score on them. Even so, taking them seriously is important: they are designed to give you practice and feedback that will help you prepare for the exams, which are more challenging in part because you will not have multiple attempts.

Exams carry the most weight in this course because they best reflect your ability to reason independently and apply economic models on your own. Problem sets are meant to provide practice and build confidence, not to make or break your grade. The podcast project is a chance to show your ability to apply economic thinking to your life.

With that in mind, the grading structure below reflects the relative importance of each course component. In particular, for each of the course components, I will scale your score out of 100 and then apply the following weights to create a “course score.” Course scores equal to or above a 93 earn an A, 90 earn an A-, 87 a B+, and so on. The weights are:

- Problem Sets: 10 percent. (Your two lowest scores will be dropped.)
- Podcast Project: 5 percent
- Exams: 85 percent total

Default weighting

- Midterm Exam 1: 20 percent
- Midterm Exam 2: 25 percent
- Final Exam: 40 percent

Alternate weighting

If this improves your overall grade, your lower midterm score will be dropped and the following weights will be used automatically:

- Midterm: 35 percent
- Final Exam: 50 percent

If it helps you, we may curve the exam grades. We would do this for each exam and potentially for your final score as a whole. For example, if you get an 85 on a midterm but the average is 75 and the standard deviation is 5, you’ve done quite well and your ultimate grade would reflect that. At this point I can’t be more specific about how exactly we will scale the grades (it depends on the distribution of scores).

Passing the final exam is required to pass the course. That is, a minimum score of 63 on the final exam after any scaling or curving is required to pass the course.

Problem Sets and Assignments

There will be approximately 11 problem sets (plus an initial “Problem Set 0,” a primary purpose of which is to get you accustomed to Achieve). **Problem sets, when they are due, will be due on Fridays at 6pm.** (See the schedule on the last page of this syllabus for dates.) Please do not ask for extensions (except for perhaps on PS 0).

Your lowest two problem set scores will be dropped. (If you do not submit a problem set on time you get a 0 for the problem set.) Most of your problem sets will be submitted through Achieve, though there will be some other types of assignments that you submit via Canvas.

I encourage you to work with classmates on the problem sets. But you must submit your own assignments via Achieve (or Canvas, as appropriate).

Podcast Project

More details to come, but here's a sketch: At some point in the semester, you will produce a three-to-five minute "podcast episode" that illustrates "thinking like an economist" about a real-life situation. You may work alone or with one or two partners. The podcast should present the principle very clearly so that your classmates and even other people not in the class would learn something about economics. (We will provide more detailed guidance later.)

Alternatively, you may present your "podcast" live, in lecture. If you choose to do this and do a good job, you will get full credit PLUS a little bump. To be discussed in class.

We will share examples and a grading rubric well in advance.

Exams

There will be two midterm exams and one final exam. **The exam dates are February 12, March 26, and May 8.** There are no makeup exams. If you miss a midterm exam for any reason, your missed exam will be handled through the policy of dropping the lower midterm score.

The final exam must be taken as scheduled, except in cases of appropriately documented illness. **Passing the final exam is required to pass the course.**

Academic Accommodations

Students who are eligible for academic accommodations of some type should consult the Academic Resource Center. The ARC will confer with the course instructor and help arrange the appropriate accommodations. Students who will have exams proctored by the Academic Resource Center must schedule appointments with the ARC at least one week prior to the exam dates. David Burk is happy to discuss any accommodations or special requests with students if they would like to, however, in many cases the official correspondence from the ARC is sufficient.

Honor Code

Passing the course requires adherence to the standards of conduct outlined by the Georgetown Honor Code. Review it at <https://honorcouncil.georgetown.edu/system/policies/>. Cases of suspected cheating will be referred to the Honor Council for investigation. Cheating or other forms of academic dishonesty can result in failing the class.

***Tentative* Schedule** (see Canvas as the course progresses for up-to-date calendar)

Lecture		Date	Textbook Chapter	Topic
1	Thurs.	8-Jan		Introduction
2	Tues.	13-Jan	1	“Core Principles”
3	Thurs.	15-Jan	2	Demand
4	Tues.	20-Jan	3	Supply
5	Thurs.	22-Jan	4	Equilibrium
6	Tues.	27-Jan	5	Elasticity
7	Thurs.	29-Jan	7	Welfare
8	Tues.	3-Feb	6	Taxes, Price and Quantity Controls
9	Thurs.	5-Feb		Applications / Buffer
	Tues.	10-Feb		Review / Buffer
10	Thurs.	12-Feb		MIDTERM 1
	Tues.	17-Feb		NO CLASS -- MONDAY CLASS SCHEDULE
11	Thurs.	19-Feb	8	Comparative Advantage, Gains from Trade
12	Tues.	24-Feb	9	International Trade
13	Thurs.	26-Feb	10	Externalities and Public Goods
	Tues.	3-Mar		SPRING BREAK
	Thurs.	5-Mar		
14	Tues.	10-Mar	11	Labor Market
15	Thurs.	12-Mar	12	Wages and Discrimination
16	Tues.	17-Mar	13	Inequality and Social Insurance
17	Thurs.	19-Mar		Applications / Buffer
18	Tues.	24-Mar		Review / Buffer
	Thurs.	26-Mar		MIDTERM 2
19	Tues.	31-Mar	14	Market Structure & Market Power
	Thurs.	2-Apr		EASTER BREAK
20	Tues.	7-Apr	15	Entry, Exit, & Long-Run Profits
21	Thurs.	9-Apr	16	Pricing Strategies
22	Tues.	14-Apr	17	Strategic Management
23	Thurs.	16-Apr	18	Game Theory
24	Tues.	21-Apr	20	Decisions under Uncertainty
25	Thurs.	23-Apr		Applications / Buffer
26	Tues.	28-Apr		Review / Buffer
	Fri.	8-May		FINAL EXAM — 12:30p - 2:30p